

Sleaze Marketing

Sleaze in the blogging sense doesn't mean sleaze as on the overall Internet front. It's not necessarily porn.

It's more intellectual and how your trust is being undermined and you are cheated.

Take a telemarketer for example. He simply calls and tells you that he has something to sell. If you are not interested, you end the conversation. On a blog, though, you may never know that something is being sold to you. Call it subliminal if you will, but most prefer the term underhanded!

There are companies that are making a fortune off this. Either by peddling their own products or by getting others to do it for them. They hire people who have expertise in a specific area—say, gadgets—and turn them into Net-based stealth marketers.

Here's what they do: they insinuate themselves into a blogging or chat community. They hang out in the community until they become trusted contributors and likeable personalities with some expertise. And then they mention a product they've just 'tried'. They don't pitch it—that would be too obvious—they just mention it kindly with a bit of excitement. Just a bit.

A job well done! Thanks to the affirmative information from a trusted friend, there's now a whole community that will go out and buy or try the new product. Easy as that. Viral marketing at its best. Get lots of people in a group to become your tipping point, and you've just got a whole lot of cheap marketing.

But isn't there something wrong with this picture? If every aspect of the Web is a chance for manipulation and abuse, whom do we trust? How do honest people compete in this environment and scrupulously manage their marketing or web or competition challenges?